Unfortunately, Fat Loss Really Is This Simple

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Jul 07, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vtU6cbXI84U Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Brandon Carter, personal trainer for 27 years, presents a four-variable fat-loss formula — calories, protein, steps, and lifting — explains the science behind why it works, and shows how to track it effortlessly using AI tools.

📑 Contents

🧮 The Core Fat-Loss Formula [0:46]

- **The foundational math:** every pound of fat requires burning 3,500 calories more than you consume
  - To lose 1 lb/week → 500-calorie daily deficit
  - To lose 2 lbs/week → 1,000-calorie daily deficit (7,000 calories over 7 days)
- The four-variable formula (works for average adults; adjustments needed for very large or very small individuals):
  - **Calories:** bodyweight in pounds × 10 = daily calorie target
    - Example: 200 lb person → 2,000 calories/day (Brandon's own target)
  - **Protein:** 1 gram per pound of bodyweight per day
    - Purpose: preserve as much muscle as possible while in a deficit
  - **Steps:** 20,000 steps per day
  - **Lifting:** full-body workouts 3–5 times per week
- Brandon's credentials: personal trainer since 1999 (27 years), trained thousands of clients
- Claims the formula works regardless of age, sex, or body type — "all mammals, possibly even amphibians and reptiles"

🔥 Why Cardio Alone Fails: The Four Ways Your Body Burns Calories [2:10]

- Brandon observed aerobics instructors at top gyms who were still overweight despite cardio being their job — illustrates why cardio-only approaches fail
- The body burns calories through four distinct mechanisms:

Mechanism	What It Is	% of Total Calories Burned
BMR (Basal Metabolic Rate)	Keeping organs running, breathing, staying alive	60–70%
Thermic Effect of Food (TEF)	Digesting and breaking down food	8–10% (implied)
Exercise (cardio, lifting, sprints)	Deliberate physical training	0–10%
NEAT (Non-Exercise Activity Thermogenesis)	Walking, cleaning, pacing, standing, daily movement	Variable — most controllable

- Key insight: **exercise only accounts for 0–10% of total calorie burn** — far less than most people assume
- NEAT is the lever you have the most control over
  - You can turn it up almost indefinitely without the downsides of intense cardio
  - Intense cardio has diminishing returns and real costs:
    - Strains the body and requires recovery time
    - Negatively affects hunger hormones (leptin and ghrelin), increasing appetite
    - Makes you more sedentary the rest of the day, actually reducing NEAT
    - Studies show people doing lots of intense cardio rest more during the day
- The hunger hormone trap with intense cardio:
  - Running a mile burns ~100 calories for the average person
  - But the leptin/ghrelin disruption can make you hungry enough to eat an extra handful of almonds or a banana — each ~100 calories
  - Net result: zero caloric benefit despite the effort and sweat

> Walking sidesteps this trap entirely — low stress, no hormonal blowback, no recovery needed, easy to repeat every single day.

🚶 Why 20,000 Steps Beats Intense Cardio [3:46]

- Walking is low-stress, requires minimal recovery, doesn't spike hunger hormones, and can be done daily without fatigue accumulation
- Studies show low-intensity cardio (like walking) retains more muscle than intense cardio
- Calorie burn from 20,000 steps:
  - 200 lb person → ~1,000 extra calories burned

    - 300 lb person → ~1,500 extra calories burned

- 20,000 steps = roughly 8–10 miles depending on stride length
- How to break it into manageable chunks throughout the day:
    - Morning walk: ~5,000 steps
    - After lunch: ~4,000 steps (transcript says "40,000" but context makes clear this is ~4,000)
    - During calls/meetings: pace on balcony, around office, or around desk
    - Additional opportunistic steps: walk instead of drive, take stairs instead of elevator
    - Evening walk: ~6,000 steps
        - At a moderate pace, 6,000 steps takes roughly 30–40 minutes
        - If it takes longer, just walk faster
- Important caveat: if you're eating poorly, the extra calories burned from steps won't matter
- Benefit for joints/CNS: walking is not hard on the central nervous system or joints (unless extremely overweight, in which case build up gradually)

🍗 Why Protein Is the Priority [5:36]

- Target: **1 gram of protein per pound of bodyweight per day**
- Why not the often-cited 0.8g/lb from studies?
    - Studies are done in controlled environments; real life is not controlled
    - FDA allows food labels to be off by up to 20% in either direction
    - A protein bar labeled "10g protein" could legally contain 8g or 12g
    - The 1g target builds in a buffer for this real-world inaccuracy
- Three reasons to prioritize protein:
    - **Muscle retention:** keeps muscle while in a caloric deficit
    - **Satiety:** keeps you fuller longer; carbohydrates are comparatively addictive and less filling over time
    - **Thermic effect:** protein has by far the highest calorie-burning cost during digestion

Macronutrient	Calories Burned During Digestion
Protein	20–30% of calories consumed
Carbohydrates	5–15% of calories consumed
Fat	0–3% of calories consumed

- Practical implication: if you eat 100 calories of protein, only ~70–80 net calories actually reach your body after digestion
- Brandon notes fitness influencers rarely discuss this thermic advantage of protein
- Brandon became a personal trainer in 1999 during the Clinton administration and trained 10 people a day — experience informs his 1g recommendation over academic minimums

📱 How to Track Calories and Macros with AI 7:27

- Tracking is non-negotiable: "You have to track both the calories you burn and the calories you consume"
- Brandon has tracked for 20+ years; before smartphones it was done in notebooks; then MyFitnessPal; now AI
- **Recommended method: Claude (AI) synced with Apple Health**
  - Claude is the only major LLM (as of recording) that syncs directly with Apple Health
  - Workflow:
    - Log food by describing it (e.g., "3 oz chicken breast") OR just take a photo and let Claude estimate
    - Upload a photo of a food label directly
    - Claude returns calories and macros for that meal
    - Claude also shows a running daily total of calories and macros consumed
    - Claude pulls calorie-burn data from Apple Health (sourced from Oura Ring or other tracker)
    - Claude then shows your real-time caloric deficit for the day
  - Brandon calls this "the greatest thing I've ever seen" and a "complete game changer"
- **Alternative: ChatGPT or Gemini**
  - Take a screenshot of Apple Health or your fitness tracker (Whoop, Oura, Garmin, etc.)
  - Upload it and ask: "This is how many calories I've burned today — tell me what my deficit is"
- **To get Brandon's exact AI tracking prompt:**
  - DM him on Instagram (@KingKeto) the word **"tracking"**
  - He has separate prompts for ChatGPT and Claude
  - The prompt is too long to post on YouTube
- Tools and devices mentioned:
  - **Oura Ring** — Brandon's preferred wearable; tracks calories burned, syncs with Apple Health, worn 24/7, charges once a week, blends with any attire including suits
  - **Whoop** — formerly used but looks out of place in formal wear
  - **Garmin** — mentioned as another option
  - **Digital food scale** — Brandon carries one everywhere, including restaurants, but acknowledges most people won't do this; photo estimation is "good enough"
- Restaurant tracking tip: tell the AI the restaurant name and dish (e.g., "I'm at Mastros, this is the creamed spinach") — LLMs know chain restaurant recipes and can estimate accurately

🥑 What About Carbs and Fats? 9:58

- Brandon's position: carb/fat split doesn't matter much for body composition — calories and protein are what drive results
  - "I've seen people get in great shape with high carbs"
  - Fill remaining calories with whatever ratio of carbs and fat makes you happy

- Brandon personally has been **ketogenic for 11 years straight**
  - His reasons are benefits beyond body composition:
    - Immune system boost (cites studies on keto and immune function)
    - Claims he hasn't been sick or had a cold in 11 years
    - Skin clarity — recommends going keto for a month for anyone with acne or skin issues
  - Notes these are personal benefits and does not mandate keto for viewers

🔗 Wrap-Up and Next Steps 10:54

- Summary of the formula one more time:
  - Calories = bodyweight (lbs) × 10
  - Protein = 1g per pound of bodyweight
  - Steps = 20,000/day
  - Lifting = 3–5 full-body sessions per week
- More aggressive fat-loss protocols exist in other videos (e.g., getting super ripped in 2 weeks, or losing significant fat in 4 days)
- This video's protocol is described as his "least aggressive" approach
- **To get the AI tracking prompt:** DM @KingKeto on Instagram the word **"tracking"**
- Brandon mentions he is on week 1 of experimenting with peptides (tirzepatide, Mots-c, and others) — too early for results; updates to follow